

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 6: Rising Ranks

Day 32 Since Awakening

The message notification appeared while Hayami was practicing earth manipulation on the roof, trying to compress stone into denser forms as the Advanced Manual instructed.

[MESSAGE FROM: SATO KENJI]

Amamiya. Got another job if you're interested. C-rank Gate, scheduled for tomorrow 0600. Same deal—combat support, handle adds and stragglers. Pay is ¥150,000. Team is experienced, but we're short on reliable support after our last guy transferred to a guild. You in?

P.S. - Bring that proper weapon you were supposed to buy.

Hayami read the message three times, their mind immediately calculating. C-rank Gate. One full rank above the last one. The recommended level for C-rank was usually 35-50. They were Level 17.

But their stats were another story. Intelligence at 80, Agility at 68, mana pool at 900. The Elemental Adaptation Cloak reducing damage and enhancing their attacks. Storm Fang and all their skills.

They weren't a typical Level 17 Hunter. Not even close.

And ¥150,000 for a single day's work—double the previous job. Plus, the experience gain from higher-level monsters would be significant. C-rank Gates meant Level 30+ enemies. Maybe even a Level 40 boss.

The risk was real. But so was the opportunity.

Hayami typed their response: *I'm in. See you at 0600.*

Day 33 Since Awakening - 05:47 AM

Gate #SB-623 was in an industrial district, far enough from residential areas that if something went wrong, the collateral damage would be limited. The Gate itself was larger than the D-rank ones Hayami had seen—nearly five meters tall, pulsing with a sickly orange light that made their skin crawl.

Sato was already there, checking equipment with his combat team. The same three D-rank fighters from before, plus the C-rank mage. When Sato saw Hayami approach, his eyebrows rose.

"You actually got a weapon." He gestured at Storm Fang, strapped to Hayami's hip. "And armor. Looking almost professional now."

"Figured it was time to invest in not dying." Hayami adjusted the Elemental Adaptation Cloak. The garment drew a few appreciative glances from the combat team.

"That's C-rank equipment," Takeshi, the hammer-wielder, said with surprise. "How's an E-rank affording gear like that?"

"Spent everything I had." Not quite true, but close enough.

Sato nodded approvingly. "Smart. Equipment can mean the difference between life and death." He pulled up his tablet. "We've also got three E-ranks joining as miners. Should be here any—ah, there they are."

Three Hunters approached the Gate checkpoint. All young, probably early twenties, with the nervous energy of people trying to look confident. Their equipment was basic—borrowed weapons, minimal armor. Their Hunter licenses showed E-rank, levels 8, 9, and 11.

The one in front, a stocky guy with a borrowed axe, noticed Hayami and did a double-take. "Another E-rank? Wait, you're on the combat team?"

"Combat support," Hayami corrected.

The three miners exchanged glances. The stocky one—his license said "Tanaka Ryo"—laughed. "You're joking, right? An E-rank doing combat in a C-rank Gate? That's suicide."

"Thanks for the concern," Hayami said flatly.

"No, seriously." One of the others, a thin woman with nervous hands, spoke up. "I've heard about E-ranks trying to punch above their weight. They always die. Always. You should switch to mining with us."

"I'm fine where I am."

Tanaka shook his head. "It's your funeral, man. Don't say we didn't warn you."

"Enough." Sato's voice cut through the conversation like a blade. "Amamiya handled a D-rank Gate without a scratch and took down over thirty monsters solo. They've earned their spot on combat support. You three focus on your own jobs and let me worry about team composition."

The miners backed off, but Hayami could see the skepticism written clearly on their faces. They thought Hayami was an idiot. A dead man walking. Just another E-rank who'd overestimated their abilities.

Let them think that. The gap between perception and reality would speak for itself.

Sato turned to Hayami, his voice lowered. "Ignore them. You've got the skills and you've clearly invested in proper gear. Just remember—C-rank monsters hit harder and move faster. Stay alert, manage your resources, and don't try to be a hero."

"Understood."

"Good." Sato raised his voice to address the full team. "Alright, everyone. This is Scorched Valley, a C-rank fire-element Gate. Expect high temperatures, Fire Salamanders, Magma Golems, and possibly a boss-level Inferno Drake if we're unlucky. Stay hydrated, watch your positioning, and don't touch anything glowing red. Questions?"

Hayami had one. "My element is lightning. Any issues with electrical attacks in a fire-element Gate?"

Sato considered. "Shouldn't be a problem. Fire and lightning don't interact badly. Just be careful with your mana consumption—the heat can be draining." He paused. "You've got lightning manipulation? That's not in your registration."

"Recently developed," Hayami lied smoothly. The Association still thought they only had basic lightning output. No need to correct that misunderstanding.

"Well, that explains the confidence. Lightning's good against most monster types." Sato checked his watch. "We go in five minutes. Last checks."

Hayami pulled up their status one more time:

[LEVEL: 17] [HP: 560/560] [MANA: 900/900]

[STATS]

- Strength: 50 (+8 from cloak)
- Agility: 68 (+8 from cloak, +5 from boots, +15% from trait)
- Vitality: 56 (+8 from cloak, +3 from boots)
- Intelligence: 80 (+8 from cloak, +5 from sword, +10 from ring)
- Sense: 52 (+8 from cloak)

[SKILLS READY]

- Advanced Lightning Strike
- Lightning Step
- Chain Lightning
- Lightning Domain
- Enhanced Perception (Passive)

They were as ready as they'd ever be.

**[NOTICE: You have entered a C-Rank Gate] [Gate Name: Scorched Valley] [Estimated Difficulty: C]
[Recommended Level: 35-50]**

The heat hit like a physical force. Hayami's Elemental Adaptation Cloak immediately activated its protection, the 30% elemental resistance making the environment merely uncomfortable instead of dangerous. Around them, the landscape was alien—rivers of slow-moving lava cut through black stone, geysers of steam erupted from cracks in the ground, and the air shimmered with heat distortion.

The miners immediately started sweating. Tanaka looked like he was regretting every life choice that had led to this moment.

"Formation!" Sato commanded. "Miners stay at the rear, minimum ten-meter distance from combat. Amamiya, position between combat team and miners. Everyone moves together."

The first monsters appeared within minutes.

[FIRE SALAMANDER - LEVEL 32] x6 [HP: 2,800/2,800 each]

They were the size of large dogs, their scales glowing with internal fire, leaving burning footprints on the stone. Fast, aggressive, and working as a pack.

The combat team engaged immediately. Takeshi's hammer crushed one salamander's skull in a single hit. The other D-rank fighters moved with practiced efficiency, their weapons enhanced with water-element enchantments that sizzled against the salamanders' superheated scales.

Two salamanders broke through the formation, heading straight for the miners.

Hayami moved.

Lightning Step activated, and suddenly they were between the salamanders and their targets. The monsters barely registered Hayami's presence before Advanced Lightning Strike caught the first one center-mass.

The difference from Basic Lightning Strike was dramatic. The bolt didn't just damage—it exploded, the enhanced power punching through scales and flash-cooking the salamander from the inside out. The creature died before it hit the ground.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [FIRE SALAMANDER DEFEATED] [+1,280 EXP]

The second salamander lunged at Hayami's exposed side. Enhanced Perception kicked in, and time seemed to slow. Hayami could see every detail—the angle of attack, the heat building in the salamander's throat for a fire breath, the exact moment to dodge.

They pivoted, drew Storm Fang, and channeled lightning through the blade. The sword cut through scales like paper, the electrical enhancement turning a decent cut into a lethal strike.

[FIRE SALAMANDER DEFEATED] [+1,280 EXP]

Behind them, the miners stared. Tanaka's mouth was literally hanging open.

"Eyes forward!" Sato barked. "More incoming!"

The raid progressed through three chambers, each one hotter than the last. Hayami fell into a rhythm—Lightning Step for mobility, Advanced Lightning Strike for high-priority targets, Storm Fang for close combat, Chain Lightning when groups clustered together.

The experience poured in. Level 32 salamanders gave 1,280 EXP each. Level 35 Magma Golems gave 1,820 EXP. Hayami had killed seventeen monsters personally by the time they reached the fourth chamber.

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 17 → LEVEL 18] [+5 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 18 → LEVEL 19] [+5 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

Two levels in under three hours. Hayami held off on distributing the points, wanting to assess the full raid first.

The combat team had noticed Hayami's performance. Takeshi kept glancing back, his earlier skepticism replaced with grudging respect. The C-rank mage had even complimented Hayami's Chain Lightning technique, saying the branching pattern was "textbook perfect."

The miners, by contrast, had gone very quiet. They trudged along in the rear, harvesting stones from defeated monsters, occasionally whispering to each other when they thought no one was listening.

Hayami caught fragments: "...how is an E-rank..." "...that equipment must be..." "...maybe they lied about their rank..."

Let them speculate. The Association's rank assessment was increasingly irrelevant. Hayami's actual capabilities were what mattered.

The boss chamber was massive—a natural amphitheater with lava pools on all sides and a ceiling that disappeared into smoke and darkness. In the center, coiled on a raised platform of stone, was the Inferno Drake.

[INFERNO DRAKE - LEVEL 42] [BOSS MONSTER] [HP: 35,000/35,000]

It was enormous. Easily eight meters long, covered in overlapping scales that glowed like forge coals. Its eyes were molten gold, intelligent and malevolent. When it saw the team enter, it uncoiled with terrifying grace and

roared—a sound that made the air vibrate and sent loose stones tumbling from the walls.

"Combat team, standard boss formation!" Sato's voice was steady despite the obvious danger. "Miners and support, position at the entrance. Amamiya, you know the drill—handle adds, don't engage the boss."

The fight began with a gout of flame that would have incinerated anyone caught in it. The combat team scattered, moving with practiced coordination to surround the drake. Takeshi drew aggro with his shield, tanking hits that would have killed Hayami instantly. The D-rank fighters struck at joints and weak points. The C-rank mage launched ice spells that sizzled against the drake's superheated scales.

Then the adds spawned.

Fire Salamanders. Dozens of them, emerging from lava pools around the chamber's perimeter.

[FIRE SALAMANDER - LEVEL 32] x24

Twenty-four salamanders. All Level 32. All heading toward the combat team's exposed rear.

Hayami didn't hesitate.

"Lightning Domain!"

The skill activated, and a hemisphere of crackling electricity exploded into existence around Hayami. Ten-meter radius, continuous damage to anything inside it, all lightning attacks enhanced by 50%.

The salamanders charged into the domain and immediately began taking damage. Not enough to kill them instantly, but enough to slow them down and weaken them significantly.

Hayami drew Storm Fang and activated Lightning Step, moving through the swarm like a thunderbolt. Advanced Lightning Strike, enhanced by the domain, killed salamanders in single hits. Chain Lightning branched between targets, each arc stronger than it had any right to be. Storm Fang carved through scales like they were paper.

The miners watched from the entrance, no longer even pretending to work. They stared at Hayami—E-rank, same registration as them—soloing two dozen C-rank monsters simultaneously.

[MULTIPLE FIRE SALAMANDERS DEFEATED] [+30,720 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 19 → LEVEL 20]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 20 → LEVEL 21]

[NOTICE: You have reached Level 20!] [CLASS ADVANCEMENT AVAILABLE] [Your class can now evolve based on your combat style and abilities. Please select advancement path after completing the current raid.]

The notification flashed, but Hayami pushed it aside. The boss fight was still ongoing, and more adds were spawning.

The battle continued for twenty minutes—the longest, most intense fight of Hayami's life. Wave after wave of salamanders. Then golems. Then something called Fire Wraiths that phased through physical attacks and required pure elemental damage to kill.

Hayami handled them all. Lightning Domain's thirty-second duration with a five-minute cooldown meant careful timing. Mana management became crucial—even with 900 total mana and the ring's regeneration, Hayami had to use potions twice.

But they survived. Adapted. Thrived.

When the Inferno Drake finally fell—Sato's sword through its throat, the C-rank mage's ice spike through its heart—the chamber fell silent except for the crackle of dying flames.

[INFERNO DRAKE DEFEATED] [RAID COMPLETE] [+8,400 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 21 → LEVEL 22]

Hayami stood in the middle of the chamber, surrounded by dissolving monster corpses, their armor scorched and their mana at 127/900. But alive. Victorious. Five levels gained in a single raid.

Sato approached, his expression unreadable. Then he clapped Hayami on the shoulder—hard enough to almost knock them over.

"That," he said, "was the most impressive combat support work I've seen from anyone below C-rank. Hell, most C-ranks couldn't have held that many adds alone." He looked at Hayami's equipment, then at Hayami's face.

"You're not really E-rank anymore, are you?"

"Association still says E."

"Association's wrong." Sato grinned. "I'm putting you on my priority contact list. When I need someone who can actually handle combat support instead of just babysitting, you're my first call."

Behind them, the three miners had stopped even pretending to work. They just stared.

The loot distribution took thirty minutes. The boss had dropped rare materials worth hundreds of thousands of yen. Hayami's contracted payment of ¥150,000 hit their account, plus another ¥85,000 from their share of the monster stones.

Tanaka approached as they were preparing to leave. He looked uncomfortable.

"Listen, about what I said before the raid..."

"Don't worry about it," Hayami said.

"No, I was out of line. I thought—" He gestured helplessly. "I thought you were just another E-rank trying to prove something and getting yourself killed. But what you did in there..." He shook his head. "That was D-rank work. Easy. Maybe even low C-rank."

"Thanks."

"How?" The nervous woman—her license said "Mori Yuki"—had joined them. "How is an E-rank that strong? The Association's assessment can't be that wrong."

Hayami considered the question. How much truth to reveal? In the end, they settled for partial honesty. "The assessment measures your abilities at the moment of Awakening. It doesn't account for growth. I've been training. A lot. Every day since I Awakened."

"But stats don't increase that much from training," Tanaka protested. "Everyone knows that. You get a few points here and there, but nothing dramatic."

"Maybe most people don't train hard enough." Hayami adjusted Storm Fang on their hip. "Or maybe the System works differently for different people."

They left before the conversation could continue. Some secrets were better kept.

Back at their apartment, Hayami collapsed onto the bed and pulled up their notifications. Five level-ups. Twenty-five stat points to distribute. And a class advancement waiting for their decision.

But first, the stats. They reviewed their current distribution:

[STATS] (without equipment)

- Strength: 50
- Agility: 60
- Vitality: 48
- Intelligence: 72
- Sense: 44

Looking at the numbers, Hayami frowned. Intelligence and Agility were high—excellent for their lightning-based combat style. But Strength and Sense were lagging behind significantly.

Just because they fought primarily with magic didn't mean they could neglect physical stats. Strength affected their melee damage with Storm Fang, their ability to wear heavier armor, their overall physical resilience. And Sense... Enhanced Perception was already powerful, but it scaled with the Sense stat. Higher Sense meant better threat detection, faster reaction times, improved accuracy.

They'd been dumping points into Intelligence and Agility because those stats had obvious, immediate combat benefits. But that was short-term thinking. For long-term survival and capability, they needed balance.

Hayami distributed the twenty-five points with careful consideration:

- Strength: +10 (to bring it closer to 60)
- Sense: +10 (to match Agility)
- Intelligence: +3 (to maintain growth)
- Vitality: +2 (for survivability)

[UPDATED STATS] (without equipment)

- Strength: 60 (+10)
- Agility: 60
- Vitality: 50 (+2)
- Intelligence: 75 (+3)
- Sense: 54 (+10)

[WITH EQUIPMENT:]

- Strength: 68 (+8 from cloak)
- Agility: 76 (+8 from cloak, +5 from boots, +15% from trait)
- Vitality: 61 (+8 from cloak, +3 from boots)
- Intelligence: 98 (+8 from cloak, +5 from sword, +10 from ring)
- Sense: 62 (+8 from cloak)

The changes were immediate. Hayami's body felt more balanced, more integrated. The Strength increase made them feel solid, grounded, capable of handling physical combat without relying entirely on magic. The Sense increase sharpened their Enhanced Perception to razor clarity—they could now detect the neighbor's heartbeat through the wall if they focused.

But more importantly, they felt ready for what came next. Their Intelligence was approaching 100, which would unlock new thresholds of elemental power. Their physical stats were finally catching up to their magical ones.

This was what a real Hunter looked like. Not over-specialized, not glass cannon mage or pure melee fighter. Balanced. Adaptable. Capable in any situation.

Now, for the class advancement.

[CLASS ADVANCEMENT AVAILABLE]

[Based on your combat performance and abilities, you have unlocked the following advancement paths:]

[1. Elemental Duelist] - Specializes in combining weapon combat with elemental attacks. +15% melee damage, +15% elemental damage, unlocks synergy skills between physical and magical attacks.

[2. Storm Mage] - Pure elemental specialization focusing on lightning mastery. +30% lightning damage, +200 maximum mana, unlocks advanced lightning techniques.

[3. Arbiter's Path] - Unique class advancement tied to your role as Arbiter of the Primordial Cycle. Balanced growth across all combat styles. Unlocks multi-element synergies. Required for future elemental masteries.

Hayami read the third option twice. "Required for future elemental masteries."

That made the choice simple. The System had a plan for them—seven elements, progressive mastery, the role of Arbiter. Fighting against that path would be fighting against their core advantage.

They selected **[3. Arbiter's Path]**.

[CLASS ADVANCED: VANGUARD/MAGE → ARBITER (STAGE 1)]

[BONUSES ACQUIRED:]

- +10% damage with all elemental attacks
- +10% damage with all weapon attacks
- +5% to all stats (multiplicative)
- Passive: Elemental Harmony - When using multiple elements in combat, gain stacking damage bonus (max 25%)
- New Skill Unlocked: Elemental Shift - Switch between elemental attunements instantly. Cooldown: None. Cost: 50 Mana.

[NOTICE: This is Stage 1 of your Arbiter advancement. Future stages will unlock as you master additional elements.]

The power settled into Hayami's body like the final piece of a puzzle clicking into place. This was it. This was what the System had been building toward since day one.

Not a lightning specialist. Not a pure mage. An Arbiter—someone who commanded multiple elements with equal skill, who could adapt to any situation, who embodied balance and versatility.

Hayami checked their final stats with all bonuses:

[LEVEL: 22] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 1)] [ELEMENTS MASTERED: 1/7]

[STATS] (with equipment and class bonuses)

- Strength: 71
- Agility: 80
- Vitality: 64
- Intelligence: 103
- Sense: 65

Intelligence had broken 100. Their mana pool was now 1,030. With the Elemental Adaptation Cloak's 20% boost and the Arbiter's 10% boost, their elemental attacks were 30% stronger than base.

And they still had five Premium Reward Boxes unopened.

One month since Awakening. E-rank in registration, D-rank in reality, with combat performance approaching low C-rank.

Hayami smiled and opened the Advanced Earth Manipulation manual. Time to push the second element toward mastery.

The grind continued.

[END OF CHAPTER 6]